CM0081 Formal Languages and Automata
§ 1.5 The Central Concepts of Automata Theory

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Preliminaries

Conventions

- The number and page numbers assigned to chapters, examples, exercises, figures, quotes, sections and theorems on these slides correspond to the numbers assigned in the textbook (Hopcroft, Motwani and Ullman 2007).
- The natural numbers include the zero, that is, $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$.
- The power set of a set A, that is, the set of its subsets, is denoted by $\mathcal{P}A$.

Alphabets and Strings

Definition

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Examples

$$
\begin{aligned}
\Sigma_1 &= \{0, 1\}, \\
\Sigma_2 &= \{a, b, \dots, z\}, \\
\Sigma_3 &= \{\, x \mid x \text{ is a Unicode codepoint} \,\}.
\end{aligned}
$$

Alphabets and Strings

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Conventions
Alphabets: $\Sigma, \Gamma, \ldots$
Symbols: $a, b, c, \ldots$
Strings: $w, x, y, z, \ldots$

All Strings over an Alphabet

Definition

Let Σ be an alphabet. The **set of all the strings over $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}$** (including the empty string), denoted Σ^*, can be inductively defined by the following clauses:

(i) Basis step: $\varepsilon \in \Sigma^*$,

(ii) Inductive step: If $x \in \Sigma^*$ and $a \in \Sigma$ then $xa \in \Sigma^*$.

Or, equivalently, by using the following inference rules:

$$\frac{}{\varepsilon \in \Sigma^*} \qquad\qquad \frac{x \in \Sigma^* \qquad a \in \Sigma}{xa \in \Sigma^*}$$

Operations on Alphabets

Definition

Let a be a symbol on an alphabet Σ. The **powers of** $\mathbf{a}$, denoted a^n, with $n \geq 0$, is the string formed by n repetitions of the symbol a (see, e.g. (Kozen 2012)). This operation is recursively defined by:

$$
\begin{aligned}
(-)^{(-)} &: \Sigma \times \mathbb{N} \to \Sigma^* \\
a^0 &= \varepsilon, \\
a^{n+1} &= a^n a.
\end{aligned}
$$

Operations on Strings

Definition

Let Σ be an alphabet. The **length** of a string x on Σ, denoted $|x|$ is the number of symbols in x. This function is recursively defined by

$$
\begin{aligned}
|-| &: \Sigma^* \to \mathbb{N} \\
|\varepsilon| &= 0, \\
|xa| &= |x| + 1.
\end{aligned}
$$

Operations on Strings

Definition

Let Σ be an alphabet. The **concatenation** of strings is recursively defined by

$$
\begin{aligned}
(-) \cdot (-) : \Sigma^* \times \Sigma^* \to \Sigma^* \\
x \cdot \varepsilon = x, \\
x \cdot ya = (x \cdot y)a.
\end{aligned}
$$

That is, let $x = a_1 a_2 \dots a_n$ and $y = b_1 b_2 \dots b_n$ two strings, then

$$x \cdot y = a_1 a_2 \dots a_m b_1 b_2 \dots b_n.$$

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Notation

We remove the dot in the concatenation, that is, $xy := x \cdot y$.

Operations on Strings

Some properties of concatenation

Let x, y and z be strings.

(i) Concatenation is associative, that is, $x(yz) = (xy)z$.

(ii) The empty empty word is the unit for concatenation, that is, $x\varepsilon = \varepsilon x = x$.

(iii) Concatenation is not commutative, that is, $xy \neq yx$.

Operations on Strings

Example

Let Σ be an alphabet and let x and y be strings over Σ. Prove that

$$|xy| = |x| + |y|.$$

Operations on Strings

Proof

By structural induction on y.

- Basis step ($y = \varepsilon$):

$$\begin{aligned} |x\varepsilon| &= |x| && \text{(def. of concatenation)} \\ &= |x| + |\varepsilon| && \text{(def. of length)} \end{aligned}$$

- Induction step ($y = wa$):

$$\begin{aligned} |x(wa)| &= |(xw)a| && \text{(def. of concatenation)} \\ &= |xw| + 1 && \text{(def. of length)} \\ &= (|x| + |w|) + 1 && \text{(IH)} \\ &= |x| + (|w| + 1) && \text{(arithmetic)} \\ &= |x| + |wa| && \text{(def. of length)} \end{aligned}$$

■

Operations on Strings

Proof

By structural induction on y (or by mathematical induction on $|y|$).

- Basis step ($y = \varepsilon$) (or $|y| = 0$, then $y = \varepsilon$):

$$\begin{aligned} |x\varepsilon| &= |x| && \text{(def. of concatenation)} \\ &= |x| + |\varepsilon| && \text{(def. of length)} \end{aligned}$$

- Induction step ($y = wa$) (or $|y| = n + 1$, then $y = wa$ where $|w| = n$):

$$\begin{aligned} |x(wa)| &= |(xw)a| && \text{(def. of concatenation)} \\ &= |xw| + 1 && \text{(def. of length)} \\ &= (|x| + |w|) + 1 && \text{(IH)} \\ &= |x| + (|w| + 1) && \text{(arithmetic)} \\ &= |x| + |wa| && \text{(def. of length)} \end{aligned}$$

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Operations on Strings

Strings, length and concatenation in Haskell

```haskell
data List   a = Nil | Cons a (List a)
data RList  a = Lin | Snoc (RList a) a
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lengthR :: RList a -> Int
lengthR Lin           = 0               -- Eq. 1
lengthR (Snoc xs x)   = lengthR xs + 1  -- Eq. 2
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```
data List   a = Nil | Cons a (List a)
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lengthR :: RList a -> Int
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```

```
(+++) :: RList a -> RList a -> RList a
(+++) xs Lin           = xs                  -- Eq. 1
(+++) xs (Snoc ys y)   = Snoc (xs +++ ys) y  -- Eq. 2
```

Operations on Strings

Example

Prove that `lengthR (xs +++ ys)` =`lengthR xs + lengthR ys`.

Operations on Strings

Example

Prove that `lengthR (xs +++ ys)` = `lengthR xs + lengthR ys`.

Proof by structural recursion on ys

- Basis step (ys is `Lin`):

```
lengthR (xs +++ Lin)
 = lengthR xs                        (Eq. 1 of (+++))
 = lengthR xs +++ lengthR Lin        (Eq. 1 of lengthR)
```

Operations on Strings

Proof by structural recursion on |ys| (continuation)

- Induction step (ys is `Snoc ys' y'`):

```
lengthR (xs +++ (Snoc ys' y'))
 = lengthR (Snoc (xs +++ ys') y'))            (Eq. 2 of (+++))
 = lengthR (xs +++ ys') + 1                   (Eq. 2 of lengthR)
 = (lengthR xs + lengthR ys') + 1             (IH)
 = lengthR xs + (lengthR ys' + 1)             (arithmetic)
 = lengthR xs + lengthR (Snoc ys' y)          (Eq. 2 of lengthR)
```

∎

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Let x be a string on an alphabet Σ. The **powers of $\mathbf{x}$**, denoted x^n, with $n \geq 0$, is recursively defined by

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Operations Alphabets

Definition

The **n-power** of an alphabet Σ, denoted Σ^n, is the set of strings of length n over Σ.

Examples

Given $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$ then

$$
\begin{aligned}
\Sigma^0 &= \{\varepsilon\}, \\
\Sigma^1 &= \{0, 1\}, \\
\Sigma^2 &= \{00, 01, 10, 11\}, \\
\Sigma^3 &= \{000, 001, 010, 011, 100, 101, 110, 111\}.
\end{aligned}
$$

Operations Alphabets

Example

Let Σ be an alphabet. Then

$$\Sigma^* = \Sigma^0 \cup \Sigma^1 \cup \Sigma^2 \cup \cdots$$

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If Σ is an alphabet and $L \subseteq \Sigma^*$ then L is a **language** over Σ.

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$$\{\varepsilon, 01, 10, 0011, 0110, 1001, 1100, \dots\}$$

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- $\{\varepsilon\} \neq \emptyset$
- The set of binary numbers whose value is a prime
- The set of legal C programs

Languages

Question

Is the set of legal English words a language?

Decision Problems

Definition

Let a set A the domain of a problem. A **decision problem** on A is a function (see, e.g. (Kozen 2012))

$$f : A \to \{0, 1\}.$$

Decision Problems

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Some questions

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(ii) Is it a language or a problem?

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(i) Is it a problem or a decision problem?

(ii) Is it a language or a problem?

(iii) Is the problem decidable or undecidable?

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Some questions

(i) Is it a problem or a decision problem?
(ii) Is it a language or a problem?
(iii) Is the problem decidable or undecidable?
(iv) Is the problem tractable or intractable?

References

- John E. Hopcroft, Rajeev Motwani and Jefferey D. Ullman [1979] (2007). Introduction to Automata Theory, Languages, and Computation. 3rd ed. Pearson Education (cit. on p. 2).
- Dexter C. Kozen [1997] (2012). Automata and Computability. Third printing. Undergraduate Texts in Computer Science. Springer. DOI: 10.1007/978-1-4612-1844-9 (cit. on pp. 9, 34).